From the Little One app

Our Baby Girl: The First Year

A month-by-month guide for new parents

General guidance based on WHO and Indian Academy of Paediatrics advice. Not a substitute for your doctor.

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Welcome, new parents

Congratulations on your little one! This book walks with you through the first year, one month at a time. Keep it simple: feed, sleep, love, and ask your doctor whenever you are unsure.

How to use this book

Read the chapter for your baby's age. Mark vaccine dates. Show the danger-signs page to everyone who looks after the baby.

A promise

Every baby is different. If your baby does something a little earlier or later than this book says, that is usually normal. Your doctor knows your baby best.

The first week

Feeding

Start breastfeeding within the first hour. The first yellow milk (colostrum) is precious: it protects the baby. Feed 8 to 12 times a day, whenever the baby shows hunger signs.

Only milk

Give only breast milk (or formula if your doctor advises) for 6 months. No water, honey, gripe water, janam ghutti or sugar water.

Cord care

Keep the cord stump clean and dry. Do not put oil, powder, turmeric or anything else on it. It falls off by itself in 1 to 2 weeks.

Jaundice

Many babies look a little yellow on days 2 to 5. See a doctor quickly if the yellow appears in the first 24 hours, spreads to the legs and feet, or the baby is very sleepy and not feeding.

Bathing

Sponge baths until the cord falls off. Keep the room warm. Never put oil in the nose or ears, and no kajal in the eyes.

Wet nappies

From day 5, expect at least 6 wet nappies a day. This tells you the baby is getting enough milk.

Safe sleep

Back to sleep

Always put the baby to sleep on the back, on a firm flat surface. This lowers the risk of sudden infant death.

Keep the bed clear

No pillows, soft toys or thick blankets near the face. A light cotton cloth is enough in Indian weather.

Close to you

Let the baby sleep in your room, in a cradle or a separate space next to your bed, for the first 6 months.

How much

Newborns sleep 14 to 17 hours a day in short stretches. Day and night settle slowly over 3 to 4 months.

Crying and soothing

Why babies cry

Hunger, a wet nappy, wind, tiredness, too hot or cold, or just wanting to be held. Check these one by one.

Soothing

Hold the baby close, swaddle snugly, rock gently, make a soft 'shhh' sound near the ear, or offer a feed. Burp after every feed.

Colic

Some healthy babies cry for hours in the evening between 2 weeks and 4 months. It passes. Take turns with family so nobody gets exhausted.

Never shake

If you feel angry or overwhelmed, put the baby down safely in the cradle and step away for a few minutes. Never shake a baby.

Caring for your baby girl

Cleaning

Always wipe from front to back when changing nappies. This keeps germs away from the urine passage. Use plain water and soft cotton.

Normal in the first weeks

A little white discharge, or even a few drops of blood from the vagina in the first 1 to 2 weeks, is common. It comes from the mother's hormones and stops by itself.

Swollen breasts

Small breast swelling, sometimes with a drop of milk, can happen in girls and boys. Do not squeeze or massage it; it settles in a few weeks.

Raising a confident girl

Give her the same food, attention, play and dreams as any child. Read to her, praise her effort, and let her explore. Confidence begins in the cradle.

Body safety later

From around 3 years, teach the correct names of body parts and simple rules: nobody touches your private parts, and you can always tell amma or nanna.

Saving for her

Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana is a government savings scheme for girls under 10. Check the current interest rate at a post office or bank.

Month by month

Month 1

Looks at faces, startles at loud sounds, lifts the head briefly on the tummy. Give a little tummy time every day while awake.

Month 2

First real smiles, cooing sounds, follows your face with the eyes. Talk and sing to the baby a lot.

Month 3

Holds the head steadier, opens hands, brings hands to the mouth, laughs. Day and night start to settle.

Month 4

Holds and shakes a rattle, pushes up on the arms, may roll from tummy to back.

Month 5

Reaches for toys, rolls both ways, knows familiar people, blows bubbles.

Month 6

Sits with support, turns to its name, starts first foods with milk. Time for teeth care with a soft cloth when the first tooth comes.

Months 7 to 8

Sits alone, passes toys between hands, babbles 'ba-ba', 'ma-ma'. May feel shy with strangers.

Months 9 to 10

Crawls, pulls to stand, picks small things with finger and thumb. Keep coins and small objects out of reach.

Months 11 to 12

Walks holding furniture, says 1 to 2 words, waves bye-bye, eats soft family food.

When to ask the doctor

No smile by 3 months, not holding the head by 4 months, not sitting by 9 months, or losing a skill the baby already had.

Vaccines

Why

Vaccines protect your baby from serious diseases. Government centres give the main vaccines free under the Universal Immunisation Programme.

Schedule (IAP)

Birth: BCG, OPV 0, Hepatitis B 1. 6, 10 and 14 weeks: DTP, IPV, Hepatitis B, Hib, Rotavirus, PCV. 6 and 7 months: Influenza, Typhoid. 9 months: MMR 1. 12 months: Hepatitis A. 15 months: MMR 2, Varicella, PCV booster. 16 to 18 months: DTP, Hib and IPV boosters.

After a vaccine

Mild fever, fussiness or soreness for a day is common. Ask your doctor about paracetamol drops and the right dose. Keep the vaccination card safe; the app reminds you of each date.

First foods from 6 months

Start

At 6 months, keep breast milk and add soft home food 2 to 3 times a day, a few spoons at first.

Good first foods

Rice kanji, ragi java, dal water then mashed dal, soft khichdi with ghee, mashed banana, stewed apple, mashed vegetables like carrot and pumpkin.

Avoid under 1 year

No salt, sugar or honey. No cow's milk as the main drink (small amounts in food are fine). No whole nuts or hard pieces that can choke.

Water

Small sips of boiled and cooled water with meals from 6 months.

Hygiene

Wash hands, use clean bowls, and give freshly made food. Throw away leftovers the baby has eaten from.

Danger signs: see a doctor now

Go to a doctor or hospital immediately if the baby

has fever in the first 3 months (38°C / 100.4°F or more), or feels very cold; is not feeding or vomits everything; has fast or difficult breathing, or the chest pulls in; has fits (convulsions); is very sleepy or hard to wake; has yellow palms or soles; has a red, swollen or smelly cord; has blood in the stool; has very few wet nappies or a sunken soft spot on the head.

Keep ready

Your doctor's number, the nearest hospital's address, and 108 for an ambulance.

Caring for amma

Rest and food

Sleep when the baby sleeps. Eat home food with dal, vegetables, fruit and plenty of water. Let family handle cooking and visitors.

Baby blues

Feeling teary or low in the first 2 weeks is common and passes.

When it is more

If sadness, worry or no interest in anything lasts more than 2 weeks, or you have thoughts of harming yourself or the baby, talk to your doctor today. Postpartum depression is common and treatable.

Nanna and family

Take night turns, burp and change the baby, and give amma time to rest. Caring for amma is caring for the baby.

Government schemes and savings

PM Matru Vandana Yojana

Rs 5,000 for the first child in two instalments, and Rs 6,000 more if the second child is a girl. Apply through your Anganwadi centre or ASHA worker with Aadhaar, bank account and the MCP card.

Documents for the baby

Get the birth certificate early, then Baal Aadhaar. Most schemes need them.

Free care

Free vaccines at government centres; Anganwadi services give nutrition support and growth checks for mothers and children under 6.

Savings plans

Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana (girls under 10), Public Provident Fund, and NPS Vatsalya (from Rs 250 a year) are government-backed. Rates change every quarter; check at a post office or bank. This is information, not financial advice.

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